

► **FROM ITS HUMBLE** beginnings in 1992 as a charitable organisation to its evolution into a regulated small finance bank, sustainability has never been an afterthought at ESAF Small Finance Bank (SFB)—it's been its essence.

"Sustainability has been embedded in the very DNA of our organisation," says K. Paul Thomas, MD & CEO of ESAF SFB. Long before ESG was recognised as a global standard, ESAF had already established a dedicated Natural Resource Management department. "Over time, this department evolved into the Sustainable Banking Department when ESAF became a bank. It is committed to overseeing how we deliver long-term value to our customers and stakeholders while adhering to rigorous sustainability standards."

54 | Therefore, when ESAF Small Finance Bank (SFB) won the Business Today award for India's Most Sustainable Companies in the BFSI category, it was a clear recognition of its purpose-driven journey.

Today, ESAF SFB boasts an ESG score of 68.1—well above the industry median of 51.8—underscoring its leadership in sustainable banking. From financial inclusion to ethical governance and green finance, the bank's operations are firmly aligned with the UN's Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs).

But ESAF's sustainability journey hasn't been defined by policy alone. It's been a steady march of purpose-driven innovation. "Our bottom-up approach has always focused on customer centricity and social impact," Thomas explains. "By addressing the unmet needs of those at the bottom of the pyramid through deep understanding, ESAF SFB ensures customer loyalty and, thereby, business scalability. This has resulted in a deeper customer connection through

WHEN POLICY MEETS PURPOSE

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